

What to Expect: The Day of Your Surgery

A walkthrough of your laparoscopic cholecystectomy (gallbladder removal), from arrival to going home.

Before You Leave Home

- Confirm your arrival time with the surgical team — usually 1–2 hours before your scheduled procedure.
- Do not eat or drink anything unless your team told you otherwise (see “How to Prepare” for fasting instructions).
- Take only the medications your surgical team approved, with just a small sip of water.
- Bring your photo ID, insurance card, and a list of your current medications.
- Leave jewelry, watches, and other valuables at home.
- Bring a small bag for glasses, hearing aids, or dentures if you wear them.
- Wear loose, comfortable clothing that's easy to change out of.
- Arrange for a responsible adult to drive you home and stay with you for the first 24 hours — this is required, not optional.

Checking In

When you arrive, you'll check in at registration or the surgical unit and change into a hospital gown. A nurse will confirm your health history, take your vital signs, and place an IV line in your hand or arm for fluids and medication.

Meeting Your Care Team

- **Your nurse** will prepare you for surgery and answer questions.
- **The anesthesiologist** will review your anesthesia plan and ask about allergies or past reactions to anesthesia.
- **Your surgeon** will review the procedure, answer any last questions, and confirm your consent.

Heading to the Operating Room

You'll walk or be taken by stretcher to the operating room. Anesthesia is given through your IV, and you'll be fully asleep (general anesthesia) for the entire procedure, which typically takes about 30–90 minutes depending on your anatomy and how the surgery goes.

In Recovery

You'll wake up in a recovery area where nurses monitor your vital signs and pain level. Feeling groggy, having a sore throat, or mild nausea are all common and temporary.

Going Home or Staying Overnight

Many patients go home the same day. Some stay one night for observation if their surgeon recommends it — both are normal outcomes and don't necessarily mean anything went wrong.

Before You're Discharged

- You'll be offered a light snack or drink once you're alert.
- Your nurse will review wound care and medication instructions with you.
- You'll receive discharge paperwork and any prescriptions.
- Your ride must be present — you cannot be discharged to drive yourself.

Your First 24 Hours at Home

- Rest and avoid strenuous activity for the remainder of the day.
- Do not drive, drink alcohol, or operate machinery for at least 24 hours.
- Take prescribed pain medication as directed.
- Eat and drink normally as you're able, unless told otherwise.

Call Your Care Team Promptly If You Notice

- Severe pain not relieved by your medication
- Heavy bleeding from an incision site
- A fever
- Repeated vomiting or inability to keep fluids down

This information is general education about a common procedure and does not replace advice from your own surgeon and care team. Instructions can vary by patient — always follow what your care team tells you, and call them with any questions or concerns.